at Depsang and Demchok. But that doesn't rule out the Chinese attempting an incursion in other areas, like they did at Yangtse (in Arunachal Pradesh, in December 2022), or they might try to infringe into the buffer areas," warns Lt Gen. Sharma.

Since 2020, Indian and Chinese militaries have beefed up their presence in Ladakh. In retaliation to large-scale infrastructure development by the Chinese near the LAC, India has accelerated its own process of building roads, bridges and airfields for faster deployment of men and materiel. Recently, satellite pictures revealed that the Chinese military has constructed helipads close to the LAC. Their proximity to areas like Depsang and Gogra indicates a strategic focus on rapid deployment. Additionally, underground bunkers and expanded air bases signal preparations for long-term presence in the contested Aksai Chin. For example, 10 Chinese helistrips have come up opposite Daulat Beg Oldie, India's northernmost corner, near Aksai Chin.

Though high-ranking officials of both countries have struck optimistic notes, only Modi and Xi can, through their personal efforts, dispel the lingering trust deficit and complete the unfinished business on the LAC. ■



"THERE IS PROGRESS IN BORDER TALKS...75 PER CENT OF DISENGAGEMENT PROBLEMS ARE SORTED OUT. WE STILL HAVE SOME THINGS TO DO"

S. JAISHANKAR
Minister of External Affairs, speaking at the Geneva Centre for Security Policy

UTTAR PRADESH

YOGI, AKHILESH IN BYPOLL JOUST

By Prashant Srivastava



SUMIT KUMAR

A NEW CONFIDENCE
SP chief Akhilesh Yadav at a public meeting in Azamgarh, Aug. 17

The ruling BJP has an outsized majority in the Uttar Pradesh assembly, so why then is the state and, to a certain degree even New Delhi, waiting with bated breath for the byelections in 10 seats there? Well, the party's dismal Lok Sabha results for one: its cave-in from 62 seats to 33 was like the hit to the solar plexus that nearly felled the whole body. The public spats that erupted within–between saffron stalk, root and sundry branches–have not ceased. As a consequence, Yogi Adityanath and his 'bulldozer' government look less than rock-solid for perhaps the first time. On the other hand, the opposition Samajwadi Party (SP) looks a lot more peppy after becoming the party with the most MPs from the state–37, with ally Congress snaffling six more.

The bypoll dates haven't been announced yet but Yogi has already assigned 30 of his ministers seat-wise responsibilities to ensure the BJP puts up a good show. The seats, too, are critical: the SP had won five in the 2022 election, the BJP three and NDA allies Nishad Party and Rashtriya Lok Dal (an SP partner then) one each. Nine of the seats were vacated